

Becoming Ilona

A Grade 6 lesson on Judy Abrams' Tenuous Threads

DESIGNED BY BRANDON GLUCK

GRADE	6
SUBJECT	Social Studies (primary), Language (secondary)
TIME	60 minutes (one period)
CURRICULUM	Ontario Grade 6 Social Studies (2023 revision), expectations A3.7 and B3.5. Both were added in the 2023 revision under the Grade 6 Holocaust education requirement. A3.7: significant events in the history of Jewish communities in Canada, plus the impacts of antisemitism on those communities' development and identities. B3.5: Canadian government responses to human rights violations during the Holocaust, plus how postwar legislation has shaped Canada's response to acts of hate since. <i>Cite the 2023 curriculum revision, not legislation. There is no Ontario statute called the Holocaust Education Act.</i>
MATERIALS	• One copy of <i>Tenuous Threads</i> by Judy Abrams (Azrieli Foundation, 2011) per student. Free copies for Canadian educators at memoirs.azrielifoundation.org/education/memoirs/. • Printed lesson plan for the teacher; printed reflection page for each student. • Optional: classroom device with browser to play the journey-map page that accompanies this lesson.

■ Where this lesson sits

The Azrieli Foundation already publishes a six-lesson Hidden Children program built around *Tenuous Threads* and a companion memoir, a four-part Judy Abrams Activity, and a multi-week Seeking Refuge unit on Jewish immigration to Canada before, during, and after the Holocaust. This lesson is the single-period close-reading companion. When a teacher has one period and wants depth on the identity-transformation moment in the convent-arrival passage of *Tenuous Threads* (pp. 10-13), this is the lesson.

■ The Big Idea

I built this lesson because the moment Judy Abrams walked through the gate of the Ursuline Mother House at age seven, and was told her name would be Ilona for the year ahead, is the hinge the whole memoir turns on. Her parents could not protect her. The nuns could. The cost of that protection was that she had to put her own name down for a while. This lesson sits with that moment. I want to be plain about what the lesson is asking children to do: it is asking them to read what a child wrote about her own life. It is not asking them to imagine they were Judy. The IHRA's Recommendations for Teaching and Learning about the Holocaust (3.2.7) are explicit on that point, and I follow it. The work for students is to read what Judy wrote, and to think carefully about what it costs a person to be told her name is no longer her name.

By the end of this lesson:

1. **I can** describe what happened to seven-year-old Judy at the Ursuline Mother House in Budapest in 1944, using specific details from the passage.
2. **I can** explain what changed for Judy when she was given the name Ilona, citing at least two pieces of evidence from the text.

3. **I can** connect this passage to the impact of antisemitism on Jewish communities in Canada and to the experience of Jewish immigration here (Ontario Social Studies A3.7).
4. **I can** write a short reflection that uses Judy's own words to think about what a name carries for a person, without having to share more than I want to share.

[Editorial note from Brandon: I list B3.5 as a secondary alignment because the lesson's primary work is interpretive, not historical-factual. The Holocaust facts in this lesson are scaffolding for close reading, which is why A3.7 sits in the primary slot.]

Meet Judy Abrams



Photograph of Judy Abrams, Holocaust survivor and author of *Tenuous Threads*.

*Judy Abrams, author of *Tenuous Threads*.*

Note for Brandon: Source author photograph from the Azrieli Foundation Holocaust Survivor Memoirs Program directly, email memoirs@azrielifoundation.org with the lesson-plan context and request a high-resolution image cleared for educational reuse. The Foundation typically grants this for memoir-based lesson plans. The Medium feature on Judy notes that the Ursuline order in Hungary supplied Judy with a 1944 photograph of the Stefánia Street convent building, ask whether that image can also be cleared for the lesson site.

She was born **Judit Grünfeld** in Budapest, Hungary, on **April 28, 1937**. Her parents were Renée (née Kaba) and László Grünfeld; her father was actively involved in the Hungarian Zionist Organization. She was an only child in a close, middle-class Budapest Jewish household, and the family included her maternal grandmother and her Aunt Marika. Her mother used affectionate Hungarian nicknames for her, the kind of small, ordinary words a child carries through her whole life.

In **March 1944**, when Judy was six, German forces occupied Hungary. Within weeks the Hungarian government required all Jews aged six and older to wear the yellow star, and by mid-May mass deportations of Hungarian Jews to Auschwitz had begun. With the help of **Mária Babar**, a devout Catholic who had previously worked for Judy's family, Judy's parents arranged for her to be hidden by the Ursuline nuns at the **Ursuline Mother House on Stefánia Street**, near the Városliget city park, in Budapest. Her father obtained forged identity papers in the name **Ilona Papp**, a Catholic child temporarily separated, the cover story said, from her parents in the Hungarian countryside.

When Allied bombing of Budapest grew heavier in the summer of 1944, the Mother Superior moved most of the nuns and the boarding students out to the country at **Pincehely**, a village in Tolna County, southwestern Hungary. Judy went with them. After a few months Mária Babar brought Judy back to Budapest and hid her in her own apartment together with Judy's grandmother and Aunt Marika, all three living under aliases, until Soviet troops liberated the city in early 1945.

Both of Judy's parents survived. They were deported to the Bergen-Belsen concentration camp as so-called "exchange Jews", held by the SS for possible ransom, and were liberated and reunited with Judy after the war. In **1949** the family emigrated to **Montreal**. As an adult Judy taught French at the United Nations International School in New York City. Her memoir, *Tenuous Threads*, was published by the Azrieli Foundation Holocaust Survivor Memoirs Program in 2011 in a paired volume with Eva Felsenburg Marx's *One of the Lucky Ones*. Mária Babar was recognized by Yad Vashem as one of the Righteous Among the Nations in **1994**.

Judy's Wartime Path

- **Budapest, family home** , pre-1944, with parents, grandmother, and Aunt Marika.
- **Ursuline Mother House, Stefánia Street, Budapest** , spring 1944. Becomes "Ilona Papp."
- **Pincehely, Tolna County** , summer 1944. The convent household relocates to escape bombing of the capital.
- **Mária Babar's apartment, Budapest** , autumn 1944 to liberation. Hidden with grandmother and Aunt Marika.
- **Liberation, Budapest** , January-February 1945. Reunited with her mother more than a year after they parted.
- **Montreal, Canada** , 1949. The family arrives, and Judy's Canadian life begins.

See the animated map on page 7.

Sources: Azrieli Foundation Holocaust Survivor Memoirs Program, survivor profile of Judy Abrams (memoirs.azrielifoundation.org/survivor/judy-abrams); *Tenuous Threads / One of the Lucky Ones*, Judy Abrams and Eva Felsenburg Marx (Azrieli Foundation, 2011, ISBN 9781897470282); United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, "The Holocaust in Hungary" and "Budapest" entries (encyclopedia.ushmm.org); Yad Vashem Righteous Among the Nations recognition for Mária Babar (1994).

Before We Read

■ Why this lesson is different

Most of what we read in Grade 6 is fiction, or it is nonfiction at a comfortable distance, an article about a place, a passage about a process. This lesson is not that. We are going to read pages from a memoir written by a real person who is alive today. Judy Abrams was seven years old when her parents handed her over to a group of nuns in Budapest so that she would not be killed for being Jewish. She was given a new name, Ilona, and told to forget the one her mother used. The pages we will read describe the day that handover happened. Because this is a real person's account of a real moment in her childhood, the room needs to feel safe before we open the book. That is what this page is for. (IHRA Recommendation 3.2.1: create a positive, open, and safe learning environment.)

■ Our class agreement

Before we read, we agree to the following five things. These are not rules I am imposing. They are the conditions that let us read this together honestly.

1. We use Judy's name. Not "the girl in the book," not "the Jewish kid." Judy. She was a real child who lived these events, and she is still alive today. Using her name is how we keep that real.
2. We can step out of the discussion if we need to. There is no penalty for needing a moment. Walk to the back of the room, get water, sit quietly, come back when you are ready. You do not need to ask permission and you do not need to explain.
3. We do not make jokes about names, identities, or anyone's faith. Not today, and not next week either. The trust we build in this lesson is the same trust we use the rest of the year.
4. We do not ask "what would I have done?" until later in the lesson. That question is not banned, but it gets asked at the wrong time it pulls our

attention away from Judy and onto ourselves. We will get to it. We will get to it after we have understood what Judy actually did.

5. We do not write our reflections during class. Discussion happens immediately. The written reflection is given 24 hours to settle. There is a reason for this, explained below.

TEACHER NOTE

Teacher note on the 24-hour rule: I deliberately do not assign a written reflection during class. This is a trauma-informed choice drawn from the Azrieli Foundation's own published guidance on teaching memoir (*Trauma-Informed Teaching and the Holocaust*, Azrieli Foundation Holocaust Survivor Memoirs Program blog). Students who are pressured to perform an appropriate emotional response in real time often produce bad-faith answers, the thing the student thinks the teacher wants, written quickly so the bell can ring. Discussion happens immediately, while the reading is fresh, but the written piece comes the next day, when the student has had time to process and to decide what they actually think. The 24-hour gap is not about avoidance. It is about giving the writing a chance to be honest.

■ What you'll need to know before you read

Who hidden children were. "Hidden children" is the term historians use for Jewish children whose families gave them over to non-Jewish people or institutions during the Holocaust to keep them alive. Some lived in basements and attics. Others lived in plain sight, with new names and new families, going to school as the Catholic or Protestant child of a foster parent. Their Jewish identity was kept secret, from neighbours, from classmates, sometimes from the children themselves. Across Europe, about 93 percent of Jewish children were murdered. The ones who survived survived mostly through hiding. (Source: USHMM, *Hidden Children and the Holocaust*.)

Why convents. Catholic religious institutions in Hungary, convents, monasteries, boarding schools, were among the places where Jewish children were hidden in 1944 and 1945. The nuns and priests who took them in were not following an official policy. They were individuals making choices, at risk of their own lives, because hiding Jews carried the death penalty under the Hungarian Arrow Cross regime. You do not need to know the theology of these institutions to read Judy's story. You just need to know that adults made choices to protect children, and a convent in Budapest was one place where that choice was made. (Source: USHMM; Azrieli Foundation Holocaust Survivor Memoirs Program.)

What "Ilona" means. Ilona is a common Hungarian girl's name. It is the kind of name a Catholic family in Hungary might give a daughter. Judy did not choose it. Her family chose it for her, and they chose it because keeping her real name. Judit, Jutka, Juditka, would have killed her. This lesson is, at its core, about the moment a seven-year-old child is told that the name her mother calls her is no longer her name. That is the weight the passage carries. We need to walk in knowing that.

Sources cited on this page: International Holocaust Remembrance Alliance, Recommendations for Teaching and Learning about the Holocaust (2019), Recommendation 3.2.1. United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, Life in Shadows: Hidden Children and the Holocaust. The Azrieli Foundation, Trauma-Informed Teaching and the Holocaust, Holocaust Survivor Memoirs Program blog. Full reference list on Page 13.

Six Words You'll Need

These six words show up in the passage we are about to read, or in the conversation around it. We learn them now so that the first reading is uninterrupted.

REFUGE

A place where you are safe from something that is trying to hurt you. A refuge is not always a fancy place, it can be a basement, a friend's apartment, or a building you didn't grow up in. What makes it a refuge is that you are protected there.

When the storm hit, the family took refuge in the school gym.

In this passage: The Ursuline convent is a refuge for Judy. The nuns inside have agreed to keep her safe.

IDENTITY

Who a person is. Your identity includes your name, your family, the language you speak at home, what you believe, the food you grew up with, and the memories you carry. People have many parts to their identity, and most of those parts are things they did not choose, they were born into them.

Speaking Punjabi at home is part of her identity, even though she speaks English at school.

In this passage: Judy's identity is the entire subject of the reading. We are watching a child be asked to set parts of who she is aside in order to live.

ALIAS

A different name a person uses, sometimes to protect themselves, sometimes to hide. An alias is not a nickname, a nickname is a friendly version of your real name. An alias is a separate name, used on purpose, often so that the wrong people don't find out who you really are.

The author published the book under an alias because she did not want her employer to know she had written it.

In this passage: Judy is given the alias "Ilona Papp" so the people who want to harm her family cannot find her.

PERSECUTION

Being treated badly, harassed, or harmed because of who you are or what you believe. Persecution is targeted, it happens to people not because of anything they did, but because of a group they belong to. It can come from a government, from a crowd, or from individual people in power.

Many people throughout history have left their home countries because they faced persecution there.

In this passage: Judy is hiding because Jewish people in Hungary in 1944 were facing persecution from the Nazi-controlled government and its allies.

WITNESS

Someone who saw something happen with their own eyes and can describe what they saw. A witness has firsthand knowledge, they were there. The word also carries a sense of responsibility: a witness is someone who can speak to the truth of an event.

She was a witness to the accident, so the police asked her what she had seen.

In this passage: Judy is a witness to her own childhood during the Holocaust. The book we are reading is her account of what she saw and lived through.

TESTIMONY

The story a witness tells, in their own words, about what they saw or lived through. Testimony is not the same as a textbook explanation, a textbook tells you what happened in general; testimony tells you what one specific person experienced. Testimony is how history holds onto the people inside it.

The grandmother's testimony about coming to Canada in the 1950s was recorded for the family archive.

In this passage: *Tenuous Threads* is Judy Abrams' testimony. We are not reading a summary of the Holocaust, we are reading one survivor's first-hand account of one stretch of her childhood.

TEACHER NOTE

Teacher note: Pre-teach these six terms before students open the memoir. The first reading should not be interrupted by vocabulary stops. I picked these six because each one shows up in the passage *or* in the way we will need to talk about the passage afterward. "Refuge," "alias," and "persecution" appear in the events of the reading itself. "Identity" is the analytic frame for the whole lesson. "Witness" and "testimony" name the kind of text we are reading, this is how I move students from "we are reading a story" to "we are reading a person's account," which is the move that gives the rest of the lesson its weight.

The Reading

■ Anchor quotes for close reading, part 1 of 2

Teacher direction: distribute the memoir before this page

Distribute pages 10-13 of *Tenuous Threads* (Azrieli Foundation, 2011) to students. Read the passage aloud, or have students read silently for eight minutes. The passage covers Judy's arrival at the Ursuline Mother House and the moment she becomes "Ilona". Free copies of the memoir are available to Ontario educators at memoirs.azrielifoundation.org/education/memoirs/. Order at least three weeks before teaching for guaranteed delivery. The four anchor quotes below (two on this page, two on page 6) are short illustrative lines for close-reading commentary; the full reading happens in the book.

■ Anchor Quotes for Close Reading

"Nobody would call me 'Judit' or 'Jutka' or 'Juditka' for almost a year."

ABRAMS, 2011, P. 10

WHY THIS LINE MATTERS

Read the sentence the way Judy wrote it. She does not say "I lost my name" or "my name was taken away from me". She says nobody would call her by it. The loss is described from the outside in, through other people's mouths, not from inside her own. That is a craft choice worth pausing on with Grade 6 readers. A child who chooses passive language here is telling us something about how the change felt: it was not something she did, it was something that happened around her. The three pet-name forms Judit, Jutka, Juditka also do quiet work; they show us that this was a loved child with a family who used many small affectionate versions of one name.

“I was to become Ilona Papp, a Catholic child temporarily separated from her parents in the Hungarian countryside.”

ABRAMS, 2011, P. 10

WHY THIS LINE MATTERS

The sentence reads almost like a job description. “Was to become” is the language of an assignment, of something a child is told she will be. The cover story is laid out in three calm pieces, a Catholic child, separated from her parents, in the countryside, and each piece is a fact Judy will need to know if she is asked. Notice what the sentence does not say. It does not say what is true: a Jewish child, separated from her parents because her parents are about to be deported, hidden in a city. The whole line is shaped by what has to be hidden. For Grade 6 readers, this is a chance to talk about the difference between the words a person uses out loud and the truth those words are protecting.

NOTICE

Judy doesn't write “they took my name away”. She writes that nobody would call her by it. That's a different sentence. Losing a thing is one kind of loss. Becoming unrecognizable to the people around you is another. A seven-year-old felt the second one and chose those exact words sixty years later.

LISTEN

Read the three names aloud: Judit, Jutka, Juditka. They get smaller and warmer each time. These were the names a Hungarian Jewish family used at home. We hear an entire household in three syllables before we hear what the household is about to lose.

WONDER

The phrase “was to become” sounds the way a teacher's instructions sound. It's the grammar of a task assigned to a child. Ask students: who is the speaker hearing those instructions from? The text doesn't tell us in this line. That silence is part of the meaning.

The Reading

■ Anchor quotes for close reading, part 2 of 2

■ Anchor Quotes (continued)

“On the day my mother and I arrived at the Ursuline Mother House a strange woman in a black floor-length gown opened the gate.”

ABRAMS, 2011, P. 11

WHY THIS LINE MATTERS

Judy is seven, and the sentence shows us how a seven-year-old looks at a frightening moment. She doesn't tell us the woman's face. She doesn't tell us the woman's voice. She tells us the gown: black, floor-length, on a stranger. Children remember the part of a person they can take in without making eye contact. Notice also the careful word “strange”. It can mean unfamiliar, and it can mean unsettling, and Judy lets both meanings sit in the line. The gate is the threshold of the whole memoir; everything that happens to Ilona happens on the inside of it. Grade 6 readers can be invited to underline the words Judy chose to notice and to ask why a child might focus on a piece of fabric instead of a face.

“My stomach seemed to constrict around a pebble I hadn't swallowed.”

ABRAMS, 2011, P. 11

WHY THIS LINE MATTERS

There is no pebble. That is the whole point of the line. Judy reaches for a body sentence to say a feeling sentence, because the feeling itself is too large for the words a seven-year-old has. This is a teachable definition of figurative language for Grade 6: a real thing borrowed to carry a real feeling that doesn't have its own word yet. Ask students what the pebble is. They will land on fear, dread, the lump in your throat before you cry, and they will be right, because the line is built so that any of those answers fits. The cleanest move here is to let students name the feeling Judy refuses to name directly, and to notice that Judy trusts her reader to do exactly that.

NOTICE

The first thing she remembers is the gown, not the woman. That's how a child stores a frightening grown-up: by the part that is safe to look at. Ask students what they remember about strangers from when they were small. They'll usually remember shoes, hands, a coat. Not faces.

TRY THIS

Read the pebble line a second time and ask the room: where in your body do you feel something you can't say out loud? We're not asking students to share. We're asking them to recognize that Judy is using her body to name a feeling, and that's a move they already know.

WONDER

Judy could have written “I was scared”. She didn't. She wrote a sentence that makes the reader do a small piece of figuring out. That's a writer trusting her reader. A good close-reading question for the class: why is the pebble line stronger than “I was scared” would have been?

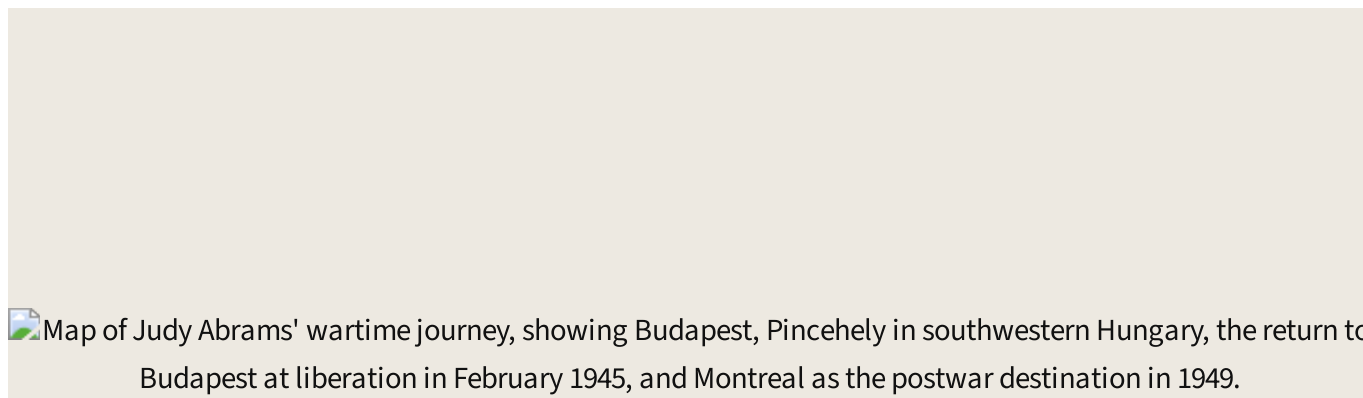
Where we go next

Now that students have read pages 10-13 of the memoir and have these four lines as anchors, turn to page 7 to scan the QR code or visit milestoneteachers.github.io/becoming-ilona-lesson/ to see the animated map of Judy's wartime journey. Then move into the comprehension work on pages 8-10.

Judy's Journey 1944–1945

■ Budapest → Pincehely → Liberation → Montreal

Before we look more closely at the words of the passage, we look at the map. Judy's story is also a geography. The places she moved through, in the order she moved through them, are part of what the words on the page mean.



QR code
linking to the
online animated
map of Judy's
journey

Scan or visit [milestoneteachers.github.io/becoming-ilona-
lesson/#journey](https://milestoneteachers.github.io/becoming-ilona-lesson/#journey) to watch the 15-second animation.

Judy's wartime path: from her family home in Budapest, into hiding at the Ursuline Mother House on Stefánia Street, briefly to Pincehely in southwestern Hungary to escape Allied bombing, back to liberation in Budapest in February 1945, and to Montreal in 1949.

TEACHER NOTE

Teacher note. Show the animation twice. First time: students watch silently. Second time: pause at each phase and ask “what just changed?” This is the lesson's only interactive technology piece. I want it to do real work, so I keep it small and intentional. Do not use the animation as decoration, as a transition between activities, or as background visual while students do something else. It is a thinking object. The whole point of the second viewing is to slow the

geography down enough that students notice the gap between *where Judy was* and *where Judy was supposed to seem to be*: the cover story said the Hungarian countryside; the truth was a Budapest convent for most of the hiding period, with a brief move out to Pincehely. The animation makes that gap visible.

Comprehension

■ Returning to Judy's words

These questions take students back into the passage to read more carefully. They are designed to be answered orally in pairs first, then shared with the whole class. No written response is required during class, see the reflection guidance on page 10.

■ Literal, close reading at the line level

1

1. Judy writes: “I was to become Ilona Papp, a Catholic child temporarily separated from her parents in the Hungarian countryside.” (Abrams, 2011, p. 10) Who in the passage gives Judy her new name? What is the new name? Where in the text do we learn the reason for the change?

2

2. Judy writes: “On the day my mother and I arrived at the Ursuline Mother House a strange woman in a black floor-length gown opened the gate.” (Abrams, 2011, p. 11) Where does Judy go on the day described in this passage? Who takes her there? Use evidence from the passage.

■ Inferential, between the lines

3. Judy describes her new name as belonging to “a Catholic child temporarily separated from her parents in the Hungarian countryside” (Abrams, 2011, p. 10). Why does this story include “temporarily” and “in the Hungarian countryside”? What is each detail meant to do?

Look-fors. A Level 3 response names that “temporarily” is reassurance, it makes the cover story sound short, ordinary, and not alarming, so a stranger asking questions has no reason to dig further. A Level 4 response goes further and notices that “the Hungarian countryside” is geographic misdirection: it explains why this child is not with her parents and why she has no documents from Budapest, and it points away from the city where her real family actually is. The strongest Grade 6 responses will say in their own words that the cover story is built to anticipate questions before they are asked.

4. Judy writes: “My stomach seemed to constrict around a pebble I hadn't swallowed.” (Abrams, 2011, p. 11) What does this image tell us that the words “I was nervous” wouldn't tell us?

Look-fors. A Level 3 response notes that the image is physical, the feeling has weight, location, and shape, while “nervous” is abstract. A Level 4 response notices the word hadn't: the pebble is not real, not something Judy did, but it is acting on her body anyway. The fear is producing a sensation that mimics swallowing a stone she never swallowed. Strong responses also note the choice of pebble rather than rock or stone, small, hard, specific, the size a seven-year-old's mouth could imagine. The figurative language makes the reader feel something the abstract word would skip past.

■ Connective, text-to-text, text-to-world

5. Compare the moment Judy is given her new name with what you read on page 4 of this lesson about *alias* and *identity*. How does the vocabulary you pre-learned change what you notice in the passage?

Look-fors. A Level 3 response uses the words *alias* and *identity* correctly when describing the passage and shows that Judy's new name is an *alias*, not a nickname. A Level 4 response goes a step further: students notice that the vocabulary frames the moment as a deliberate, protective act, not a story event. They see that knowing the word *alias* in advance lets them read Judy's sentence as a description of survival strategy rather than as a description of being given a name. The point of pre-teaching is that the second reading goes deeper than the first, and the strongest responses will show that movement.

6. The Azrieli Foundation has published over 30 first-person Holocaust memoirs by Canadian survivors. Why do you think survivors choose to write memoirs in their own words, rather than letting historians summarize their stories? What does Judy's first-person voice do that a textbook description couldn't?

Look-fors. A Level 3 response distinguishes a first-person voice from a summary and gives at least one concrete example from Judy's passage (the three pet names, the pebble image, the calm "was to become") that a textbook would not include. A Level 4 response argues for the moral weight of the choice: a memoir keeps the survivor as a person, not a statistic; it preserves voice, hesitation, and the small specific details that a summary smooths away; and it puts the reader in a relationship with one human being rather than with a faceless number. The strongest responses will name that this

*is exactly why
the Azrieli
Foundation
publishes
memoirs, to
keep the people
inside the
history visible.*

What Would You Have Kept Hidden?

This is not the question you might be expecting. The question is not “what would you have done in the Holocaust” or “what would you have done if you were Judy”. The International Holocaust Remembrance Alliance (IHRA Recommendation 3.2.7, 2019) is explicit on this point: never ask students to imagine themselves directly involved in the Holocaust. Children cannot meaningfully picture being a hidden Jewish child in 1944 Hungary, and the attempt usually produces shallow performance or genuine distress, neither of which serves the survivor's story or the student. Instead, we ask a much smaller and more honest question. If you had to pretend to be someone else for a year, to keep yourself or someone you love safe, what would be the hardest part of the new name?

■ The prompt

If you had to pretend to be someone else for a year, to keep yourself or someone you love safe, what would be the hardest part of the new name?

SENTENCE STEMS FOR YOUR OWN THINKING

You may use any of these to start your thinking, or write in your own words.

1. The hardest part for me would be ____ because ____.
2. I think I could keep ____ secret, but not ____.
3. Judy had to learn _____. I would struggle with _____.
4. What I notice about Judy is that she _____.

SENTENCE STEMS FOR PARTNER CONVERSATION

After you have written or thought through your own answer, turn to a partner. Use these to keep the conversation careful.

1. When you said _____, I thought of _____.
2. I disagree gently. I think _____.

3. What did you mean by ____?

TEACHER NOTE

Teacher note. I deliberately do not ask students to imagine themselves in Judy's situation. IHRA Recommendation 3.2.7 explicitly cautions against simulation pedagogy: students cannot meaningfully imagine being a hidden Jewish child in 1944 Hungary, and the attempt often produces shallow performative responses or genuine distress. The smaller question, what would be hard about a new name, is something students can reason about from their own lives. It opens empathy without simulation. I also want to flag the design of the second set of sentence stems: “I disagree gently” is on the page on purpose. Grade 6 partner talk benefits from a script for respectful disagreement, especially on a topic where students may want to perform certainty. Model the stems aloud once before students try them.

Source: International Holocaust Remembrance Alliance (IHRA), Recommendations for Teaching and Learning about the Holocaust, 2019, section 3.2.7. ISBN 978-3-00-064374-3.

Reflection. For Tomorrow

Written reflection on this passage happens 24 hours later, not in class today. The Azrieli Foundation's guidance on trauma-informed teaching recommends a cooling-off period between sensitive memoir content and a deeper written response, so that students sit with the reading overnight rather than rushing a paragraph while their feelings are still loud (Azrieli Foundation, *Trauma-Informed Teaching and the Holocaust*). The 24-hour gap is a deliberate pedagogical choice, not laziness or a missing instruction.

Choose ONE of the following three prompts. Tomorrow, write a 6–12 sentence response. Bring it to class for our discussion.

Prompt A, Close reading

Choose one moment from the passage that you cannot stop thinking about. Describe the moment in your own words. Then explain why this is the moment your mind keeps returning to. Use at least one quote from the text.

Prompt B, Connection to memory

Judy chose to write *Tenuous Threads* almost 70 years after the events. Why might a survivor wait that long? What would be hard about writing it sooner? What would be hard about writing it 70 years later?

Prompt C, The Foundation's work

The Azrieli Foundation publishes Canadian Holocaust survivor memoirs and provides them free to schools. Why might it matter that the memoirs are by Canadians specifically? Why might a Canadian Grade 6 student in 2026 read

the words of a Hungarian-born survivor whose memoir was published in 2011? Write your answer in 6–12 sentences.

TEACHER NOTE

Teacher note. Collect responses one full school day later. Do not grade for emotional content, grade for engagement with the text and clarity of thought. The 4-point rubric on page 12 has full criteria. A few practical reminders: read each response privately before deciding which ones to share aloud; if a student writes something that suggests they are struggling, follow up one-on-one rather than in front of the class; if a student passes on the prompt entirely, accept that and offer a different way to participate in tomorrow's discussion. The point of the reflection is not to produce a perfect paragraph; it is to give every student a private place to process the reading before the class talks about it together.

Source: Azrieli Foundation, "Trauma-Informed Teaching and the Holocaust," Holocaust Survivor Memoirs Program blog. memoirs.azrielifoundation.org/blog/trauma-informed-teaching-and-the-holocaust/.

Teacher Notes

■ Six things this lesson asks of the teacher in the room

These notes are not preamble. Each one names a specific moment that will happen, or could happen, when you teach this passage to a Grade 6 class. I wrote them the way I would tell a colleague at lunch, not the way a binder would.

TEACHER NOTE

■ 1. The silence after the read-aloud is the lesson working.

The first time you read this passage to a class, the silence afterward will feel longer than you expect. Twenty seconds is not too long. The students need a moment to land. The temptation is to fill the room with your own voice. Another sentence of context. A softening line. A question that gives them something easy to do. Resist it. When you do break the silence, start with the literal question on page 8, the lowest cognitive lift in the room. “Who gives Judy her new name? Where in the text do we learn the reason for the change?” A child who has just heard the passage can find that on the page, and finding it gives them something to hold onto while their feelings settle. The silence is not failure. It is the lesson doing what it is supposed to do. The opposite of compassion is interruption.

2. When a student steps out of the room.

A student may need to leave the room. Have a quiet exit established at the start of class. Not announced as “if you cry”. Baked into the class agreement on page 3 (“we can step out of the discussion if we need to”). Decide before the lesson where they go: a chair in the hall, the office of a trusted educational assistant, a quiet corner with a glass of water. When a student

does step out, do not follow them immediately. Send the EA, or a designated classmate they have already chosen, or no one at all if the student has signalled they want privacy. They will return when they are ready. Do not single them out on return. Continue at the same pace. [TODO Brandon: a specific Grade 6 lesson you taught about something hard, where you used this protocol, and what you learned from it.] The lesson protects the dignity of the student who needed a moment by not making the moment into a spectacle.

TEACHER NOTE

■ 3. The “but why didn't they fight back?” question.

This is the most common question a Grade 6 class will raise on this material. It is not a bad question. It is a child trying to make sense of the helplessness of the adults around Judy, and trying to put themselves on a side where they would have been brave. Three responses, in roughly this order. First: many people did resist, in many ways. The adults who hid Judy. The convent that took her in. The parents who let go of their child to a stranger so the child could live. Those are all resistance. Second: the question, asked the way it usually gets asked, quietly puts Jewish people on trial for their own survival. We do not put Judy on trial. Third: today's lesson is not about resistance. It is about what one specific child experienced. Redirect to the text. The resistance lesson is a different lesson, taught on a different day, with different scaffolding. (IHRA Recommendation 3.2.7 is the frame I am working from on this, and on most of what follows.)

4. The joke from the back of the room.

It will happen. Sometimes from a student who genuinely does not know what they are saying. Sometimes from a student testing whether you mean the class agreement on page 3. Address it directly. Immediately. In proportion. Use the language already established: “we don't make jokes about names, identities, or anyone's faith.” Do not punish in front of the class. Do not lecture. Redirect, and continue. After class, have the conversation with the student privately. Not as a discipline meeting. As a conversation about what the comment landed on, and on whom. Document the incident the way your board requires. Do not let the comment become The Story Of The Lesson.

Students calibrate to whether you handle this kind of moment like routine or like spectacle, and the calibration teaches them more than your words will.

TEACHER NOTE

■ 5. The student who already knows a lot about the Holocaust.

Some Jewish students will know more than this lesson teaches because their family has carried the story. Some students will have read voraciously about the Second World War and want to show you the books. Some will have a grandparent who survived. Do not perform deference. That turns a child into the spokesperson for a topic, which is a burden no eleven-year-old should carry on a Tuesday afternoon. Acknowledge the knowledge briefly: “your family has carried this story”, or “you have read about this before, I can tell”, and keep going. Their job is the same as everyone else's: to engage with Judy's specific words on the page in front of them. After class, ask if they would like a reading recommendation, a conversation, or simply a quiet acknowledgement. Let them choose.

6. After the bell, what to do with what you carry.

Teachers carry this material home. That is normal. It is also not sustainable across many days of teaching alone. The Sarah and Chaim Neuberger Holocaust Education Centre in Toronto runs collegial communities for teachers in this work. The Azrieli Foundation's own Holocaust Survivor Memoirs Program supplies an Educators' Catalogue and a network of teachers using these books in classrooms across Canada. Find one of those communities. Speak with someone. Not as professional development. As the company of people who already know what it is to teach this. The most professional thing a teacher of this material can do is recognize that the material has weight, and seek out the company of educators already carrying it. For me this is also personal. My grandparent was a Holocaust survivor. The work of carrying that memory forward is not separable from the work of teaching this lesson well.

A final word on scope. This sixty-minute lesson is one period, not a unit. It sits inside the larger ongoing work the Foundation already does: the Hidden Children program, the Judy Abrams Activity, the Seeking Refuge unit, the Re:Collection digital archive. It should not be the only Holocaust education a Grade 6 student receives in a year. Pair it with a survivor visit if one is available. Pair it with the broader Heritage and Identity strand. The lesson is humble inside that ecosystem on purpose. One passage, one child, one hour, taught carefully, and then continued.

Sources informing this page: International Holocaust Remembrance Alliance (IHRA), Recommendations for Teaching and Learning about the Holocaust, 2019, sections 3.2.1, 3.2.7, 3.4.3. Azrieli Foundation, "Trauma-Informed Teaching and the Holocaust," Holocaust Survivor Memoirs Program blog. United States Holocaust Memorial Museum, Guidelines for Teaching About the Holocaust, Guideline 10.

Curriculum Alignment

■ Ontario Grade 6 Social Studies (2023 revision)

A3.7, Strand A: History and Geography of Jewish Communities in Canada, Past and Present **PRIMARY ANCHOR**

Verbatim expectation: describe significant events or developments in the history of Jewish communities in Canada, including some of the ways they have contributed to Canada (e.g., events and developments: official recording of the first Jewish settler in New France [1759]; establishment of Canada's first synagogue, Shearith Israel, in Montreal [1768]; equal rights being given to Jewish people in Lower Canada [Quebec], including being able to hold public office [1832]; founding of Canada's first national Jewish organization, the Federation of Zionist Societies in Canada [1899]; establishment of Montreal's Young Men's Hebrew Association and Young Women's Hebrew Association [1910]; founding of the Canadian Jewish Congress [1919]; waves of Jewish immigration during the twentieth and twenty-first centuries from Europe, Asia, South America, and North and South Africa, increasing the diversity of Canada's Jewish community; dedication of the National Holocaust Monument in Ottawa [2017]; Special Envoy on Preserving Holocaust Remembrance and Combatting Antisemitism role created [2020]; contributions: leaders in human rights laws since the 1940s; entrepreneurs in industry and manufacturing), and identify some of the impacts of antisemitism on these communities' development and/or identities.

How this lesson addresses A3.7: Judy Abrams is the lived experience this expectation names. She is a Hungarian Jewish child who survived hiding in Budapest, joined the postwar wave of European Jewish immigration to Canada in 1949, and contributed to Canadian and Jewish communal life as a teacher and as a published memoirist. The lesson reads one passage from her own memoir and asks students to describe a specific impact of antisemitism, the loss of her name, on a Jewish child whose family later helped build the postwar Canadian Jewish community.

B3.5, Strand B: People and Environments with the Global Community

Interactions

SECONDARY ANCHOR

Verbatim expectation: describe the responses of the Canadian government to human rights violations during the Holocaust (e.g., severe restrictions on immigration and the policy of "none is too many"; the turning away of the MS St. Louis; Canada's policy to vastly restrict the number of Jewish refugees admitted from Europe, as shown by the response to the Evian Conference [1938]) and the impact that global changes in understanding and legislation around human rights since World War II have had on the development of Canada's responses to acts of hate and human rights violations.

How this lesson addresses B3.5: Canadian immigration policy in the 1940s, the "none is too many" policy, almost prevented Judy and her family from arriving here at all. The lesson surfaces this in the closing reflection on page 11, where students consider that Judy's Canadian life (the life that produced this memoir) depended on a postwar shift in Canadian policy toward Jewish refugees. The 2022 criminalization of Holocaust denial in Bill C-19 is named on page 13 as the contemporary edge of the same arc.

■ Ontario Grade 6 Language (2023 revision)

The 2023 Ontario Language curriculum fully supersedes the 2006 curriculum for Grade 6. Reading expectations now sit under Strand C (Comprehension. Understanding and Responding to Texts).

C1.6, Strand C: Comprehension

Verbatim expectation: identify the narrator's point of view, including first, second, or third person, in a variety of texts, providing evidence, and explain how using an alternative point of view would change each story.

How this lesson addresses C1.6: *Tenuous Threads* is a first-person memoir. Students name Judy's point of view and discuss what would change if a third party were narrating her arrival at the convent, what would they see, what would they miss.

C2.5, Strand C: Comprehension

Verbatim expectation: explain how the ideas expressed in texts connect to their knowledges and lived experiences, the ideas in other texts, and the world around them.

How this lesson addresses C2.5: The reflection prompt on page 11 invites students to think about names, the ones they are called by family, the ones they use at school, the ones they choose for themselves, without requiring personal disclosure. Students connect Judy's experience to ideas about identity they have encountered in other texts and in their own lives.

C3.2, Strand C: Comprehension

Verbatim expectation: make local and global inferences, using explicit and implicit evidence, to develop interpretations about various texts and to extend their understanding.

How this lesson addresses C3.2: The figurative-language micro-lesson on page 9 has students infer the unspoken feeling behind Judy's line, "My stomach seemed to constrict around a pebble I hadn't swallowed" (Abrams, 2011, p. 11). This is inference using implicit evidence in the strict sense the expectation describes.

C3.6, Strand C: Comprehension

Verbatim expectation: explain how various topics, such as diversity, inclusion, and accessibility, are addressed in texts, analyze the insights or messages conveyed, and identify different positions presented.

How this lesson addresses C3.6: Students analyze how the memoir treats Jewish identity under occupation and what insight the passage offers about identity preservation under existential threat, an insight Judy has positioned, by writing this memoir for younger readers, to reach exactly the audience now reading it.

Assessment Rubric (4-Point Scale)

The rubric assesses the written reflection completed at the start of the next class period (a 24-hour cooling-off after the lesson, in line with the Azrieli Foundation's trauma-informed teaching guidance). Students are not assessed on the content of their feelings; they are assessed on the quality of their textual engagement.

CRITERION	LEVEL 1	LEVEL 2	LEVEL 3	LEVEL 4
1. COMPREHENSION OF JUDY'S SPECIFIC EXPERIENCE IN THE PASSAGE	Names the passage in general terms; key details are missing or confused (e.g., wrong location, wrong age, wrong identity).	Describes part of the passage accurately but misses central facts (the name change, the convent setting, who arranges the hiding).	Describes Judy's arrival at the Ursuline Mother House and her renaming accurately, with most key details in place.	Describes Judy's arrival, renaming, and the role of Mária Babar and the Ursuline nuns with precise, specific details, and places the moment correctly within Budapest in 1944.
2. USE OF EVIDENCE FROM THE TEXT IN DISCUSSION AND REFLECTION	Reflection makes claims without textual evidence; quotations missing or invented.	Refers to the passage in general terms; one quotation may appear without page citation.	Uses at least one short, accurately cited quotation from the passage to anchor a claim.	Uses two or more short, accurately cited quotations to build an argument, and explains why those particular sentences carry weight.
3. EMPATHETIC ENGAGEMENT WITH JUDY'S PERSPECTIVE (ANCHORED IN THE TEXT, NOT PERFORMED)	Empathic statements are general or imagined ("I would feel sad").	Empathy is named but not tied to specific moments in Judy's writing.	Identifies a specific moment in the passage and explains, with	Identifies a specific moment, explains why it would matter to a seven-year-old child,

CRITERION	LEVEL 1	LEVEL 2	LEVEL 3	LEVEL 4
	No textual anchor.		evidence, why it would matter to a seven-year-old child.	and distinguishes between what Judy says directly and what she leaves for the reader to feel.
4. CONNECTION TO BROADER THEMES (IDENTITY, NAMES, CONCEALMENT, WITNESS)	Connection is missing or off-topic.	Names a theme (e.g., identity) without explaining how the passage develops it.	Connects Judy's experience to one of the lesson's themes and explains the connection in the student's own words.	Connects Judy's experience to a theme and to a specific second context (another text, a current event, a curriculum idea about Canadian Jewish community history) without flattening the differences between them.

Editorial note from the lesson designer: I deliberately wrote criterion 3 to reward textual engagement rather than performed feeling. Empathy in a Holocaust lesson should be evidence-anchored, never an exercise in imagining oneself into the survivor's position. This rubric language is consistent with the IHRA 2019 Recommendations 3.2.7 and 3.4.2.

Sources and Further Reading

■ Primary Source

Abrams, J. (2011). *Tenuous Threads* (paired in one volume with Eva Felsenburg Marx, *One of the Lucky Ones*). Toronto: The Azrieli Foundation, Holocaust Survivor Memoirs Program, in association with Second Story Press. ISBN 978-1-897470-28-2.

■ Curriculum Documents

Ontario Ministry of Education. (2023). *The Ontario Curriculum, Grades 1–8: Social Studies, History, and Geography* (revised edition). Retrieved from <https://www.dcp.edu.gov.on.ca/en/curriculum/elementary-sshg/grades/g6-ss>. Specific expectations cited in this lesson: A3.7 and B3.5 (added in the 2023 revision under the Grade 6 Holocaust education curriculum requirement).

Ontario Ministry of Education. (2023). *The Ontario Curriculum, Grades 1–8: Language*. Retrieved from <https://www.dcp.edu.gov.on.ca/en/curriculum/elementary-language>. Specific expectations cited in this lesson: C1.6, C2.5, C3.2, C3.6 (Strand C: Comprehension).

■ Holocaust Education Frameworks

International Holocaust Remembrance Alliance, in partnership with UNESCO. (2019). *Recommendations for Teaching and Learning about the Holocaust*. ISBN 978-3-00-064374-3. Retrieved from <https://www.holocaustremembrance.com/resources/educational-materials/recommendations-teaching-and-learning-about-holocaust>. The pedagogical decisions in this lesson, one individual story rather than statistics; no graphic imagery; no simulation or "imagine you are Judy" tasks, follow IHRA Recommendations 3.2.3, 3.2.4, 3.2.7, 3.4.1, and 3.4.2.

United States Holocaust Memorial Museum. *Guidelines for Teaching About the Holocaust*. Retrieved from <https://www.ushmm.org/teach/fundamentals/guidelines-for-teaching-the-holocaust>. See also Age-Appropriateness guidance at <https://www.ushmm.org/teach/fundamentals/age-appropriateness>. Grade 6 is the entry grade USHMM endorses for explicit Holocaust instruction; this lesson honours USHMM guidelines 9 (translate statistics into people) and 10 (no simulations).

Echoes & Reflections (joint program of the Anti-Defamation League, USC Shoah Foundation, and Yad Vashem). Retrieved from <https://echoesandreflections.org/about/>. The lesson holds critical thinking and empathy together, in line with the Echoes & Reflections framework.

USC Shoah Foundation. *IWitness*. Retrieved from <https://iwatch.ushah.org/>. The *IWitness* model of using short, carefully selected testimony clips paired with historical context informed the decision to anchor this lesson on a single passage of *Tenuous Threads* rather than the full memoir.

Yad Vashem International School for Holocaust Studies. *Pedagogical Principles for Teaching the Holocaust at the Elementary Level*. Retrieved from <https://www.yadvashem.org/education/about-school/pedagogical-principles-elementary.html>. The lesson's biographical framing of Judy across three movements, before hiding, during hiding, and as the postwar Canadian author of this memoir, is drawn from Yad Vashem's elementary-level guidance to restore the human face by leading with prewar life and post-liberation life rather than persecution alone.

■ About the Azrieli Foundation Holocaust Survivor Memoirs Program

The Azrieli Foundation Holocaust Survivor Memoirs Program publishes the unpublished memoirs of Holocaust survivors who came to Canada and distributes them at no cost to Canadian educators, school libraries, and post-secondary instructors. Free print copies, e-books, and PDFs of *Tenuous Threads* and the rest of the Azrieli Series are available at memoirs.azrielifoundation.org/education/memoirs/. The Foundation's existing four-part Judy Abrams Activity, background reading, navigation of the Re:Collection digital archive, an author biography activity, and a timeline activity, sits at memoirs.azrielifoundation.org/education/programs/judy-abrams-activity/, and the Foundation's six-lesson Hidden Children program (built around *Tenuous Threads* and a companion memoir) is at memoirs.azrielifoundation.org/education/programs/hidden-children/. International educators may request copies by emailing memoirs@azrielifoundation.org.

About the lesson designer: see page 14.

About the Lesson Designer

Brandon Gluck has taught in Ontario classrooms for over a decade, with expertise in Universal Design for Learning and differentiated instruction across multiple grade levels and subject areas. He is a technology consultant and advisor to Ontario school boards, helping districts integrate digital tools with sound pedagogy. He holds a Political Science background and taught for two years in Israel as part of his ongoing work in Jewish education. A grandchild of a Holocaust survivor, Brandon is a steadfast advocate for the Jewish community and for Israel, and the work of carrying survivor memory forward is both professional and personal for him. He designed this lesson to model what middle-grade Holocaust memoir teaching can look like when it honours both the survivor's voice and the student's developing moral imagination.

Why this lesson exists

Beginning this year, middle-grade students in Ontario will encounter the Holocaust as part of their required Grade 6 Social Studies work. The Azrieli Foundation has built a remarkable library of survivor voices in their own words. The work I want to do is bridge the two, to design lessons that bring the Foundation's published memoirs into Ontario classrooms with the seriousness they deserve, the pedagogical care the students deserve, and the moral imagination the survivors' words have already given us. This portfolio submission is one example of that work, built on a single passage from one memoir.

■ Technical Note

This lesson plan was designed in May 2026. The 14-page lesson plan was built from a custom HTML/CSS layout with print-PDF and online-classroom modes. The animated journey map on page 7 was rendered using Remotion (an open-source React-based motion graphics library) and is approximately 15 seconds long. Archival photographs are sourced from the United States Holocaust Memorial Museum Photo Archive (educational use). Curriculum citations are drawn from the Ontario Curriculum, Grades 1–8: Social Studies, History, and Geography (2023 revision). Pedagogical framing is grounded in the IHRA Recommendations for Teaching and Learning About the Holocaust (2019) and trauma-informed practices published by the Azrieli Foundation. The full source code and digital lesson are available at github.com/MilestoneTeachers/becoming-ilona-lesson.

■ Acknowledgements

The Azrieli Foundation Holocaust Survivor Memoirs Program, for publishing the memoirs that make Canadian Holocaust education possible.

*Judy Abrams, whose memoir *Tenuous Threads* (2011) is the source for this lesson.*

*The IHRA, *Echoes & Reflections*, and the USC Shoah Foundation, for the pedagogical frameworks that shape how this lesson handles difficult material.*

The Ontario Ministry of Education, for the 2023 curriculum revisions that brought Holocaust education explicitly into Grade 6.

Contact Brandon at admin@milestoneteachers.ca, feedback, questions, or to discuss curriculum work.